

Gies AI for Impact Build-A-Thon — Impact Report

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Spring 2026 · Gies College of Business · University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

Prepared for college leadership, project champions, mentors, judges, the keynote partner, the Office of the Provost, and prospective future sponsors.

Executive Summary

Over 24 hours on April 23–24, 2026, more than **120 Gies students** worked in **30 teams** to build production-grade agentic AI systems against five real business problems contributed by Gies operating leaders. **22 teams** — comprising **72 students** — completed the event end-to-end. Every team built on **Microsoft Copilot Studio**, and the event drove the **largest single-day usage of Copilot Studio recorded at UIUC**.

The Build-A-Thon was not a demo competition. Each track was anchored by a real Gies stakeholder (“project champion”) who contributed an active operational problem, sample data, and a scoring rubric students were graded against. Output was concrete: working multi-agent systems with executable workflows, leadership briefings, and dashboards built in less than 24 hours.

Beyond the build itself, the event has generated tangible downstream impact — including a commitment from the **UIUC Office of the CIO** to bring builders onto its AI Solutions Development team for the summer and into next semester — and significant external visibility through organic LinkedIn coverage by students, mentors, judges, and the keynote partner Decasonic.

- **Event details** — <https://build-a-thon.dsrs.illinois.edu/>
 - **Final results** — <https://ikompete.dsrs.illinois.edu/competition/14>
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At a Glance

Metric	Result
Students signed up	120+

Metric	Result
Teams that started	30
Teams that completed end-to-end	22 (comprising 72 students)
Tracks	5 (Business Technology · Finance & Accounting · General Innovation · Human Resources · Marketing & Sales)
Project champions (real Gies problem owners)	5
Judges	4
Mentors	7+
Preparatory workshop signups	200
Discord support tickets opened	50+
Discord messages routed to HackClaw (event AI helpdesk)	100+
Emails sent by HackClaw during the event	500+
Platform	Microsoft Copilot Studio — largest single-day usage at UIUC on record

Challenge Design — Real Problems, Real Champions

Each track was sponsored by a project champion drawn from Gies operating leadership and partner offices. The champion contributed: (a) a written challenge brief, (b) sample data drawn from real workflows, and (c) a published scoring rubric students were graded against.

Track	Challenge	Champion
Business Technology	Prospect Identification — read job postings backwards to surface consulting opportunities for the Gies Business Advisory program	Charlie Farhoodi
Finance & Accounting	Innovation Portfolio Budget Intelligence — help leaders decide which projects to stop, scale, or redeploy capital across	Adam King
General Innovation	Career Navigator — turn a student's profile into personalized career recommendations, skill	Skylar Zhang

Track	Challenge	Champion
	gaps, and a tailored job-search roadmap	
Human Resources	Candidate Evaluation System — multi-agent hiring evaluation with rubric-based scoring and audit trail	Julia Shubina Sabin
Marketing & Sales	Multi-Campaign Manager — unify marketing and sales workflows, evaluate campaign performance, draft stakeholder reports	Lindsey Savoie Halfar

The challenges were curated, not improvised. The Business Technology track alone had **five drafted briefs** that were winnowed to one final challenge — a curation process repeated in every track to ensure each problem was scoped to fit a 24-hour build while still being operationally meaningful.

From the published Prospect Identification rubric: “The goal is a 0–100 overall fit score per posting, with a clear rationale and a ranked list at the end. Two reviewers (human or AI) using this rubric on the same posting should produce scores within ± 6 points of each other. Every component above must be reproducible from the posting alone. If the agent cannot explain a score from the posting text, that score should not be used. Do not use company name prestige or personal networks as inputs to scoring.”

This was the bar across all five tracks — auditable, fair, and grounded in real operational decision-making.

The Builders — Top 5 Teams

The Top 5 overall maps directly to the five track winners — one per track. All five team photos are included with explicit consent of the participants.

1st Place — Team 007 · Magelli Scout · Business Technology

Lead: [Prateek Verma](#) · **Team:** [Anmol Aggarwal](#) · [Jeswell Mathew](#) · [Venkatesh Mehra](#) **Champion:** [Charlie Farhoodi](#) (Magelli Office of Experiential Learning)



“Every job posting is a company publicly broadcasting what they can’t do. A ‘Director of Revenue Operations’ posting doesn’t just mean they’re hiring — it means they have no revenue process today. That’s a consulting brief hiding in plain sight. We built an agent that decodes those briefs automatically.” — [Prateek Verma](#)

Magelli Scout is a fully agentic AI prospect-intelligence system that reads job postings in real time, scores them against a fairness-audited rubric, and delivers ranked consulting briefs to the Magelli Office of Experiential Learning via Power BI and Power Automate. **Magelli Scout is live.** It is exactly the kind of system the Office of Experiential Learning would otherwise pay an external vendor to build — shipped in under 24 hours by four MSBA students.

 **2nd Place — Team Geese · *HireFlow* · Human Resources**

Lead: [Purab Arora](#) · **Team:** [Mitchell Crevier](#) · [Luke Manthuruthil](#) · [Kelly Cong](#) **Champion:** [Julia Shubina](#)
[Sabin](#)



“Every time one of us hit a wall, someone else picked it up — that’s how HireFlow got built. 1,440 minutes. Straight grind.” — Purab Arora

A multi-agent hiring evaluation system that eliminates scoring drift. The hiring manager defines a custom rubric; the agent scores resume + CV against levels of responsibility, ingests interview transcripts, scores candidates against historical admission data, and aggregates rounds into one auditable decision.

3rd Place — Team YTBD · Marketing & Sales

Lead: Arrush · **Team:** Abhiraj Singh · Siddh Gandhi **Champion:** Lindsey Savoie Halfar (Gies Marcom)



Track winner in Marketing & Sales — built on Microsoft Copilot Studio against the Multi-Campaign Paid Media Management challenge.

4th Place — Team MindMatrix · Multi-Agent Career Guidance System · General Innovation

Lead: Poorva Bhide · **Team:** Juan Carlos Zapata · Yukta Mehta · Nandini Agarwal **Champion:** Skylar Zhang

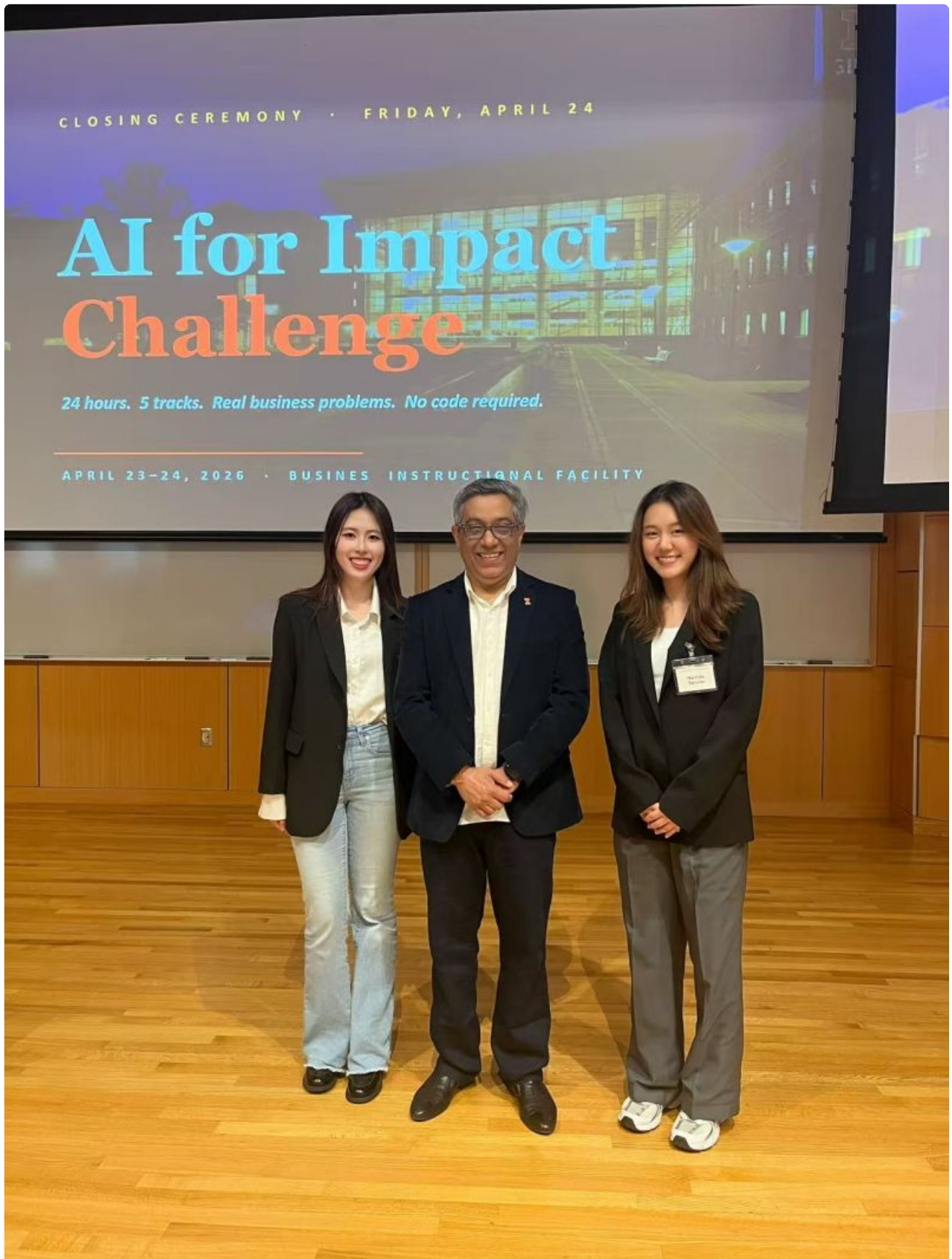


"Multi-agent systems aren't the future — they're already reshaping how decisions get made."
— Juan Carlos Zapata

A 4-agent system that transforms a student's profile (resume + inputs) into personalized career recommendations, skill gap insights with targeted learning plans, and a tailored job search roadmap — including visa-aware guidance for international students.

5th Place — Team HerLedger · EVA · Finance & Accounting

Lead: Xinying Fu · **Team:** Narinda Tanvilai **Champion:** Adam King



“Under 24 hours, we built something that thinks like a CFO and moves faster than one.” — Xinying Fu

EVA is an AI-powered portfolio intelligence advisor that evaluates innovation projects across four dimensions (Strategic Alignment · Spend Efficiency · Milestone Adherence · Signal Strength) and applies covenant-style override rules. It frames freed capital across three strategic options (Protect Near-Term Returns · Repair Portfolio Balance · Bet on Strongest Signals), reducing a 4-hour manual review to a 2-minute automated workflow.

Other Notable Builds

Beyond the Top 5, several teams produced builds that drew significant external attention. Two from the Marketing & Sales track stand out:

Multi-Campaign Paid Media Management & Performance Assistant — Team BuildForce

Team: [Glory Cheng](#) · [Zryan I. Ahmed](#) · [Deepti Purwar](#) · [Ammratansh Ghildyal](#) · **Mentor:** [Lindsey Savoie Halfar](#)

“AI is powerful, but it is not the thinking. If your understanding of the problem is vague, AI will only scale that vagueness.” — Glory Cheng

A paid media operations agent built for scale, speed, and real impact — unifying marketing and sales workflows, planning tasks, evaluating campaign performance, generating stakeholder-specific reports, and distributing them automatically. Designed to reduce reliance on external agencies.

Market Matrix — Team Market Matrix

Team: [Harvin Patel](#) · [Rushabh Jain](#) · [Hasnain Khan](#) · [Medhovarsh Bayyapureddi](#) · **Mentor:** [Lindsey Savoie Halfar](#) · **Live demo:** harvinpatel.github.io

“24 hours, no code — we built a campaign manager that actually manages campaigns.” — Harvin Patel

An AI-powered Campaign Manager: a Daily Brief that flags risks, geographical performance breakdowns, integrated finance (“inbuilt split-wise” for spend), and one-click stakeholder escalation drafted into Outlook.

In Their Own Words

The student response was striking in its candor about both the rigor and the satisfaction of shipping real systems under time pressure.

*“24 hours. One shot. We walked in with an idea and walked out with a system that turns job postings into consulting opportunities.” — **Prateek Verma**, 1st place, Magelli Scout*

*“Multi-agent systems aren’t the future — they’re already reshaping how decisions get made.” — **Juan Carlos Zapata**, General Innovation winner*

*“Every time one of us hit a wall, someone else picked it up — that’s how HireFlow got built.” — **Purab Arora**, HR winner*

*“Under 24 hours, we built something that thinks like a CFO and moves faster than one.” — **Xinying Fu**, Finance & Accounting winner*

*“24 hours, no code — we built a campaign manager that actually manages campaigns.” — **Harvin Patel**, Market Matrix*

*“It was an environment where business and technology truly aligned, where strategy and execution were not separate conversations but one.” — **Zryan I. Ahmed***

*“AI is becoming non-negotiable in work and daily life, but the real value does not come from using it for the sake of it.” — **Glory Cheng***

*“1,440 minutes. Straight grind.” — **Purab Arora***

Mentor and Judge Reflections

External judges and mentors publicly described the event as a benchmark for what student-built agentic AI can look like.

Paul Hsu (keynote · Founder, Decasonic) — [full reflection](#) — 113+ reactions, 5 reposts:

“Build to Learn. Learn to Build. Experimental learning is thriving at Illinois. ... Clear from the conversations with students, faculty, and organizers that this was more than a typical hackathon. It was a focused effort to translate emerging ideas in agentic AI into real, working systems that had impact on the university and broadly the world. Students spent 24 hours building across domains like finance, marketing, HR, and business technology, decomposing complex problems into multi-agent workflows and designing coordinated systems. ... What really stood out to me was the mindset of the student teams: an energy toward building, experimentation, and iteration. I was impressed by the level of engagement, engineering rigor and the emphasis on building real solutions. Higher education transforms students when it is aligned with applied research and hands-on building, especially in fields that are actively shaping industry innovation. The key skills of tomorrow are imagination, invention and execution.”

Sid Chakravarty (judge · AI Leader, Adjunct Professor) — full reflection: > “I was truly impressed by the depth of research each team conducted to decompose complex problem statements into multi-agent systems — designing agents that could effectively coordinate to achieve a shared objective. ... As AI matures, the role of the AI engineer is evolving into that of an Orchestrator. Success will belong to those who maintain an end-to-end view of the system, treating individual components like Lego blocks to be assembled with precision. For large, established firms, the goal is clear: we must cultivate the next generation of AI Orchestrators.”

Jake Myers (mentor · UIUC Office of the CIO) — full reflection: > “In under 24 hours, students built working AI agents that tackled real problems. Most weren’t ‘AI experts’ going in. Just some training, curiosity, very little sleep, and a lot of caffeine. The pace of learning and execution was honestly kind of wild. ... The barrier to building useful AI solutions is dropping fast. It’s less about deep specialization and more about framing the right problem and actually putting something together that works.”

Operational Excellence

A high-touch support infrastructure made the 24-hour intensity sustainable.

- **Preparatory workshops** drew **200 signups** in the weeks leading up to the event, removing the “where do I even start?” friction so teams could begin building immediately at kickoff.
- **Discord** served as the primary support channel during the event. **50+ tickets** were opened for mentor and technical assistance.
- **HackClaw**, an AI helpdesk built specifically for the event, fielded **100+ student messages** on Discord and sent **500+ emails** during the 24-hour window — answering common questions, routing requests to mentors, and learning from resolved tickets in real time. HackClaw was itself an AgentLab project, demonstrating how AI agents can be designed around real moments of work.

- **Five project champions**, supported by **seven mentors** drawn from Gies and partner offices, were instrumental in keeping every team focused and unblocked.
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Platform Adoption and Impact

The challenge produced an unusually strong adoption signal for **Microsoft Copilot Studio**:

- The event recorded the **largest single-day Copilot Studio usage at UIUC**.
 - A majority of participants entered with limited or no prior awareness of Copilot Studio. The event served as both competition and training ground for an emerging platform.
 - The depth of work (multi-agent orchestration, Power Automate flows, Power BI dashboards, Outlook drafting, Excel logging) demonstrated that mainstream business students — without coding backgrounds — can build production-quality AI workflows when scoped well.
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Strategic Alignment — Build to Learn, Learn to Build

The Build-A-Thon ran the same week Gies launched its new fully online **MSBAi (Master of Science in Business Analytics with AI)** degree, anchored on the same “Build to Learn, Learn to Build” pedagogical thesis.

Dean **W. Brooke Elliott** wrote in her [launch announcement](#): > *“Our world-class domain experts will teach people AI’s strengths and weaknesses well enough to orchestrate it using our Build to Learn, Learn to Build experiential learning approach.”*

The Build-A-Thon is the live demonstration of that thesis: students learning AI by shipping working AI systems against real Gies problems.

Downstream Impact

The event’s value extends well beyond its 24-hour window.

- **UIUC Office of the CIO talent pipeline.** [Jake Myers](#) (Office of the CIO mentor) [publicly committed](#) to bring builders from the event onto his AI Solutions Development team for the **summer and into next semester** — turning a weekend sprint into university-wide impact. *“Taking what started as a weekend sprint and turning it into something that actually sticks and makes an impact across the university.”*
- **Magelli Scout is now in production** for the Magelli Office of Experiential Learning, automating consulting prospect identification.
- **Track champions retain working systems** built against their own operational problems — across Finance, HR, Marketing, and General Innovation.

- **Decasonic relationship.** Keynote speakers [Paul Hsu](#) (Founder/Managing Partner) and [Abdul Al Ali](#) brought the perspective of a working VC firm running AI agents at scale, and Decasonic team members continued public engagement with Gies students post-event.
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Reach and Recognition

The event generated significant organic visibility on LinkedIn:

- **Vishal Sachdev's kickoff post** (April 23 evening) acknowledging the full event team is the canonical reference.
 - **Public student write-ups** from four of the five Top-5 teams (Magelli Scout, HireFlow, Career Guidance, EVA) plus the Marketing & Sales builds (BuildForce, Market Matrix) generated a combined **391+ reactions, 86+ comments, and 10+ reposts** — much of it from external industry observers.
 - **The keynote speaker himself** — [Paul Hsu](#) — published a public reflection on the event drawing **113+ reactions and 5 reposts**, providing top-tier external industry endorsement that “this was more than a typical hackathon.”
 - **Judges and mentors** ([Sid Chakravarty](#), [Jake Myers](#)) published reflections that drew an additional **80+ reactions** and brought external-industry framing to the event (“AI Orchestrator,” “leapfrog learning,” “the barrier to useful AI is dropping fast”).
 - The pre-event keynote announcement and RSVP campaign reached prospective students, faculty, staff, and alumni across the Gies network.
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Acknowledgements

The event existed because of the people below.

Keynote [Paul Hsu](#), [Abdul Al Ali](#) — [Decasonic](#)

Project Champions [Charlie Farhoodi](#) · [Adam King](#) · [Skylar Zhang](#) · [Julia Shubina Sabin](#) · [Lindsey Savoie Halfar](#)

Judges [Jacob Kinsey](#) · [Sid Chakravarty](#) · [Tarkan Bolat](#) · [Mark Moran](#)

Mentors [Lindsey Savoie Halfar](#) · [Amber Glynn](#) · [Skylar Zhang](#) · [Jake Myers](#) · [Jamie Nelson](#) · [Charlie Farhoodi](#) · [Julia Shubina Sabin](#)

Student Leaders [Ashleyyn Castelino](#) · [Keshav Dalmia](#) · [Sahib Bedi](#)

Behind-the-Scenes Support [Jeremy Samuel](#) · [Shikhar Mattoo](#) · [Shreyas Kulkarni](#)

Faculty & Staff Leadership [Adam King](#) · [Jamie Nelson](#) · [Chris Tidrick](#) · [Matias Carrasco Kind](#) · [W. Brooke Elliott](#)

Sponsoring Organizations [Gies College of Business](#) · [Agentic AI @ UIUC](#) · [Disruption Lab at Gies](#) · [BuildIllinois](#) · [Magelli Office of Experiential Learning](#) · [Data Science Research Services](#) — [Gies College of Business](#)

Dean's Office [Dean W. Brooke Elliott](#) and the Gies leadership team

Finalist Teams

All 22 teams that completed the Build-A-Thon end-to-end, comprising 72 students. Teams are listed alphabetically; named project mappings are noted where the team has publicly described their build.

Team	Members	Track	Project / Notes
007 🏆	4	Business Technology	<i>Magelli Scout</i> — 1st place overall, BT track winner
Geese 🏆	4	Human Resources	<i>HireFlow</i> — 2nd place overall, HR track winner
YTBD 🏆	3	Marketing & Sales	3rd place overall, Marketing track winner
MindMatrix 4	4	General Innovation	<i>Multi-Agent Career Guidance System</i> — 4th place overall, GI track winner
HerLedger 5	2	Finance & Accounting	<i>EVA</i> — 5th place overall, F&A track winner
BuildForce	4	Marketing & Sales	<i>Multi-Campaign Paid Media Management Assistant</i>
Market Matrix	4	Marketing & Sales	<i>Market Matrix</i> — Campaign Manager
Bob the Builders	3		
ByteCrawl	2		
Catalyst	3		
Colabs	4		
Condescending	3		
Gies Intelligence	4		

Team	Members	Track	Project / Notes
HanuMind	2		
Interstellar	3		
JKR	3		
LogicRay	4		
Monkes Never Cramp	3		
S.M.B	2		
Team Beta	4		
Uncharted	4		
Winners	3		

Looking Forward

The Spring 2026 Build-A-Thon proved a model: real problems contributed by real operating leaders, scoped tightly, supported with strong infrastructure, and judged with rigor. Three threads to build on:

1. **More champions, more challenges.** The five tracks barely scratched the surface of operational problems within Gies and partner offices. Future iterations can add tracks (e.g., Operations, Risk, Student Success) with new champions, and can extend invitations to other UIUC colleges.
2. **A persistent pipeline.** Top builders are being absorbed by the Office of the CIO's AI Solutions Development team; this pipeline can be formalized so every Build-A-Thon graduates 5–10 students directly into university-wide AI work.
3. **External sponsorship.** The combination of named-champion problems, a working platform partnership (Microsoft Copilot Studio), keynote-level industry presence (Decasonic), and demonstrated student execution makes this an attractive sponsorship venue. Future sponsors can be named for individual tracks, prizes, or the keynote slot.

The Build-A-Thon is what experiential AI education looks like when business and technology are not separate conversations.

"Build to Learn. Learn to Build."

This report was compiled from the original Spring 2026 Build-A-Thon report, public LinkedIn coverage, the released challenge briefs and scoring rubrics, and post-event materials. Full source files in `docs/impact-report/` (LinkedIn coverage, Box challenge materials, raw extract).